Moscow and perhaps to prepare the ground domestically in case of war.[173] These public statements did not help their cause with Nehru. Indian officials were aware of US concerns about credibility.[174] And the prime minister was not entirely unsympathetic to Eisenhower's difficulties related to dealing with Jiang.[175] But he continued to believe that Washington's China policy was "basically wrong"—and the longer it stood, the harder it would be to change.[176]

By mid-April, Nehru felt that the American attitude on the offshore islands had "toned down a little." He disapproved of Dulles's indication that the issue should be brought up at the UN, seeing it—correctly—as an American attempt to tie its allies' hands. He did believe, however, that the US was restraining Jiang from attacking the mainland and would itself not attack.[177] Little did he know that this was when Eisenhower and Dulles were proposing Taiwanese withdrawal from the offshore islands—in exchange for a US blockade and mining of the Strait and placement of nuclear weapons in Taiwan.[178] Before those US-Taiwanese discussions bore any result, however, Zhou made a surprising move.

At Bandung, the Chinese premier refused to renounce the use of force to reclaim Taiwan but indicated a willingness to talk directly to American officials.[179] Nehru had been frustrated with Beijing's "good deal of stubbornness,"[180] but this changed to approval after Zhou's overture. The Indian embassy in Beijing believed the offer was the effect of the Bandung conference—and validation of the Indian approach.[181] Dulles, on the other hand, claimed that it was the result of US saber rattling, especially of the nuclear kind.[182]

Dulles publicly reiterated American support for Taiwan and uncertainty about China's intentions, but noted that the US was open to testing Chinese sincerity.[183] Nehru thought the initial US response was unhelpful but, nonetheless, a step forward.[184] Glad that the US had not rejected the overture outright, he expressed his belief to Soviet leaders that Eisenhower, at least, wanted to respond positively. Furthermore, he appreciated that the president and Dulles saw Krishna Menon after the latter had traveled to Beijing. Nehru had dispatched him to Washington to encourage the US leadership to respond favorably to the Chinese invitation. Nehru approvingly noted Krishna Menon's observation that Eisenhower and Dulles were "receptive," albeit to different degrees.[185] Speaking to Indian